

MANDAR DEODHAR

THE SHE LIST UNDER 50

THE ENTREPRENEURS

The Wealth Builder

RADHIKA GUPTA, 42
MD & CEO
Edelweiss Asset Management
Mumbai

For Radhika Gupta, the journey to leading one of India's fastest-growing asset management companies (AMCs) began long before she entered the world of finance. The daughter of an Indian Foreign Service officer, she spent much of her childhood moving across countries. The turning point came when she landed a job at McKinsey in the US after seven job interview rejections. A few years later, she married Nalin Moniz, whom she had met while studying economics at the Wharton School of the University of Pennsylvania. The couple moved to India in 2009 to start Forefront Capital Management, an alternative asset management boutique. Edelweiss Financial Services bought the company in 2014, and in 2017, at the age of 33, she became CEO of Edelweiss Asset Management, one of the youngest CEOs in the country's BFSI (Banking, Financial Services and Insurance) sector. Ever since, the company has grown nearly 30 times, making it one of the fastest-growing AMCs.

WHAT MAKES HER A SHERO

From the time she took over in 2017, Radhika led Edelweiss from strength to strength, its assets under management touching over Rs 1.80 lakh crore as of Mar. 31, from around Rs 6,000 crore as of Mar. 31, 2017

"What makes me the happiest is not just the numbers but the consistency with which we have delivered, both in terms of investment performance and customer experience," she says. That has been done on the back of a wide product range, from actively managed and passive funds to global offerings, Specialised Investment Funds (SIFs) and GIFT City products. This love for variety is evident in her collection of 300-plus saris, each representing a different handloom and craft tradition of India. Bringing the same breadth to investment opportunities has helped the company evolve from a fixed-income-focused AMC into a much more equity-focused one. Its SIP (Systematic Investment Plan) book, in fact, is among the fastest-growing in the industry, crossing Rs 700 crore as of July 31.

Beyond Edelweiss, Gupta is passionate about simplifying finance for the *aam janata*. She believes asset management is a profession with a larger purpose. "We are not only responsible for building businesses but also for educating and engaging investors," she says. That philosophy has led her to coin relatable concepts such as "*dal-chawal* investing", even as her book, *Mango Millionaire*, went on to become a national bestseller.

Her biggest challenge, however, has been to innovate while operating at scale and in the public eye. Post the *Shark Tank* era, Radhika has become a well-known public figure. "Balancing growth, responsibility, visibility and innovation has, therefore, been one of my most significant leadership challenges," she says. ■

— Sonal Khetarpal

WOMAN TO WOMAN

"The glass ceiling is often much bigger in our minds than it is in reality. Don't spend too much time worrying about it. Go out there, challenge your own limitations, and break the barriers you have created for yourself. Most importantly, develop a positive relationship with ambition"